

Handcrafted Feature Optimisation and Classifier Benchmarking for Brain Tumor MRI Classification

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Abstract—Brain tumor classification from magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) supports triage of glioma, meningioma, and pituitary lesions. Most studies apply default parameters to handcrafted texture descriptors or couple exhaustive grid search to a single classifier, introducing optimisation bias and high compute cost. We present a two-phase framework on a balanced dataset of 1,500 axial MRI slices (500 per class): Phase 1 selects GLCM, LBP, DWT, and HOG hyperparameters using three classifier-free separability metrics (Fisher discriminant ratio, mutual information, Davies–Bouldin index) over 213 configurations; Phase 2 benchmarks eight classical models (SVM, KNN, random forest, XGBoost, LightGBM, logistic regression, MLP, ExtraTrees) with stratified 5-fold `GridSearchCV` on eight optimised feature compositions. On the held-out test split, the best configuration pairs KNN with the Full(opt) vector (accuracy = 0.953, macro-F1 = 0.946); SVM on Full(opt) reaches F1 = 0.912, providing an interpretable clinical baseline. Random-forest group importance confirms that HOG dominates raw importance while GLCM and statistical descriptors carry higher information per dimension, agreeing with Phase 1 separability rankings. Full statistical validation (Cohen’s κ , bootstrap confidence intervals, McNemar, Wilcoxon, Friedman–Nemenyi) is reported for the top models. These results show that separability-guided handcrafted features with rigorous classical benchmarking achieve strong MRI classification without deep learning or GPU training.

Index Terms—Brain tumor, MRI, texture features, machine learning, parameter optimisation, statistical validation

I. INTRODUCTION

Accurate discrimination of glioma, meningioma, and pituitary tumours on MRI supports treatment planning and reduces inter-observer variability in resource-limited settings [?], [?]. While deep convolutional networks dominate recent benchmarks, they require GPU resources, large labelled corpora, and offer limited interpretability—constraints that remain relevant for single-centre studies and clinical prototyping [?], [?]. Handcrafted radiomics and texture descriptors (GLCM, LBP, DWT, HOG) remain competitive on brain MRI when parameters are tuned, yet most papers rely on library defaults or grid search tied to one classifier, conflating feature quality with classifier choice [?], [?].

We address a specific gap: *no published work combines classifier-free separability scoring for joint GLCM/LBP/DWT/HOG optimisation with a comprehensive multi-classifier benchmark and full statistical validation on the same stratified split*. Our pipeline (Fig. 1) separates parameter selection (Phase 1) from classifier comparison (Phase 2),

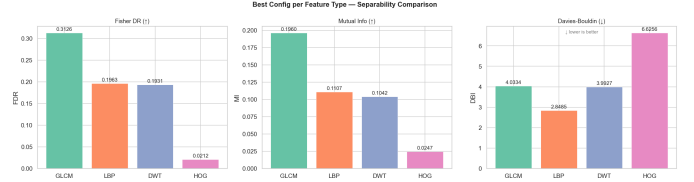


Fig. 1: Phase 1 overview: separability-guided selection of GLCM, LBP, DWT, and HOG parameters before any classifier training.

avoiding the feedback loop that inflates cross-validation scores when features and models are co-optimised.

Contributions are:

- 1) A separability-first protocol (FDR + MI + DBI) over 213 descriptor configurations, yielding published optimal settings (Tables I, II).
- 2) An eight-model Phase 2 benchmark (SVM, KNN, RF, XGBoost, LightGBM, LR, MLP, ExtraTrees) on eight feature sets with macro-F1 as the primary metric (~36,000 hyperparameter candidates; Table III).
- 3) Feature-group importance analysis (RF/XGBoost on Full(opt)) linking unsupervised Phase 1 scores to supervised rankings (Section VI).
- 4) Statistical validation: Cohen’s κ , bootstrap 95% CIs, McNemar, Wilcoxon, and Friedman–Nemenyi tests (Section VII).
- 5) A soft voting ensemble (SVM + XGBoost + LightGBM on Full(opt)) as a no-search fusion baseline.

The remainder of the paper reviews related work (Section II), describes the dataset and methods (Section III), reports Phase 1 and Phase 2 results (Sections IV–V), analyses feature importance and significance, and discusses limitations.

II. RELATED WORK

A. Handcrafted texture features for MRI

Grey-level co-occurrence matrices (GLCM), local binary patterns (LBP), histogram of oriented gradients (HOG), and discrete wavelet transforms (DWT) encode complementary tumour micro-texture [?], [?], [?]. Yu *et al.* [?] showed that texture features with an SVM classifier differentiate tumour

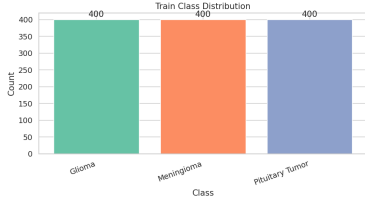


Fig. 2: Training-set class distribution after stratified split (500 samples per class).

from healthy regions on MRI with high sensitivity. Comparative studies consistently rank texture and gradient descriptors among the strongest classical representations [?], [?]. Our Phase 1 differs by selecting parameters through *classifier-free* separability metrics before any model is trained.

B. Classical ML classifiers in brain tumour classification

Support vector machines with RBF kernels remain a dominant baseline on radiomic feature vectors [?], [?]. Ensemble tree methods provide native feature-importance scores for interpretability [?], [?]. Prior benchmarks rarely compare more than three classifiers on identical handcrafted features and splits.

C. Parameter selection strategies

Default scikit-learn parameters are common; grid search coupled to a single classifier is expensive and risks overfitting the validation objective to one model family. Separability metrics offer a lightweight alternative used in feature selection but seldom applied systematically across texture families for brain MRI.

D. Gap

No study combines classifier-free separability scoring for GLCM, LBP, DWT, and HOG with an eight-model benchmark and full statistical validation on the same dataset and preprocessing chain. We fill this gap with a reproducible two-phase notebook pipeline on a fixed stratified 80/20 split.

III. METHODS

A. Dataset and preprocessing

We use a publicly available brain-tumour MRI collection (Kaggle Brain Tumor Detection & Classification) with three classes—glioma, meningioma, and pituitary tumour—balanced at 500 slices per class (1,500 images total). Images are converted to grayscale, resized to 128×128 , cropped to remove black borders ($\text{thr} = 0.05$), and contrast-enhanced with CLAHE before feature extraction. The dataset is stratified into 80%/20% train/test (fixed random seed); 5-fold stratified cross-validation on the training fold selects hyperparameters. Class balance is verified in Fig. 2 (imbalance ratio ≈ 1.0 ; SMOTE not applied).

B. Separability metrics for classifier-free selection

Phase 1 ranks descriptor configurations *before* any classifier is trained. For each hyperparameter setting we extract features on the training set and compute three complementary metrics:

- **Fisher’s discriminant ratio (FDR):** $\text{FDR} = \frac{1}{p} \sum_{j=1}^p \frac{\sigma_B^2(j)}{\sigma_W^2(j) + \epsilon}$, measuring between-class versus within-class variance per feature dimension.
- **Mutual information (MI):** $\text{MI}(X_j; Y) = \sum p(x, y) \log \frac{p(x, y)}{p(x)p(y)}$, capturing non-linear dependency between each feature and the class label.
- **Davies–Bouldin index (DBI):** cluster compactness relative to inter-cluster separation (lower is better).

Each metric is min–max normalised to $[0, 1]$ on the configuration grid; DBI is inverted so that higher is better. The composite Phase 1 score is $(\text{FDR}_n + \text{MI}_n + (1 - \text{DBI}_n))/3$. The highest-scoring setting per family is locked for Phase 2 (Table II); the full search grid is in Table I.

C. Grey-level co-occurrence matrix (GLCM)

The GLCM [?], [?] tabulates how often grey levels i and j co-occur at a given pixel offset (d, θ) . For an image quantised to L levels, the matrix $\mathbf{P}$ has size $L \times L$; we average over all distance–angle pairs and extract six Haralick properties: contrast, dissimilarity, homogeneity, energy, correlation, and angular second moment (ASM). **Output:** 6 features. **Optimal:** $d \in \{1, 2, 4, 8\}$, $\theta = 0$, $L = 128$, symmetric=True (score = 0.781).

D. Local binary patterns (LBP)

LBP [?] encodes local texture by thresholding a circular neighbourhood of P pixels on a ring of radius R . **Output:** $P+2$ histogram bins for uniform method (10 dims for $P = 8$). **Optimal:** $P = 8$, $R = 1$, uniform (score = 1.000).

E. Discrete wavelet transform (DWT)

The 2-D DWT decomposes the image into approximation (LL) and detail sub-bands (LH, HL, HH) at each scale [?], [?]. We compute mean, standard deviation, energy, and Shannon entropy per sub-band. **Output:** $4 \times (3L+1)$ features (16 at $L = 1$). **Optimal:** bior1.3, level = 1 (score = 0.994).

F. Histogram of oriented gradients (HOG)

HOG [?], [?] accumulates gradient-orientation histograms per cell with block normalisation. **Output:** 1,176 dimensions with optimal settings on 128×128 inputs. **Optimal:** 6 orientations, (16, 16) cells, (2, 2) blocks (score = 0.997).

Fig. 3 illustrates all four descriptors on one preprocessed slice using these optimal parameters.

G. Feature vectors and cleaning

Eight feature sets are built from Phase 1 optimal extractors plus first-order statistics: A (Stats), B (Tex/opt = GLCM+LBP), C (DWT/opt), D (HOG), and unions A+B, B+C, A+B+C, Full(opt) ($\sim 1,987$ raw dimensions). Before training: VarianceThreshold, Pearson correlation filter at 0.95, StandardScaler.

TABLE I: Phase 1 hyperparameter search space per descriptor family (213 configurations total). Bold values denote the selected optimum (Table II).

Family	Hyperparameter	Search values	#	Optimal
GLCM	distances	{1}, {1,2}, {1,2,4}, {1,2,4,8} , {2,4}, {4,8}	6	[1,2,4,8]
	angles (rad)	{0}, {0, $\pi/2$ }, {0, $\pi/4$, $\pi/2$, $3\pi/4$ }, 6-angle set	4	[0]
	levels	64, 128 , 256	3	128
	symmetric	True , False	2	True
LBP	P (points)	8 , 12, 16, 24	4	8
	R (radius)	1 , 2, 3	3	1
	method	uniform , nri_uniform, ror	3	uniform
DWT	wavelet	haar, db1, db2, db4, sym2, coif1, bior1.3	7	bior1.3
	level	1 , 2, 3	3	1
HOG	orientations	6 , 9, 12	3	6
	pixels_per_cell	(8,8), (16,16)	2	(16,16)
	cells_per_block	(2,2), (3,3)	2	(2,2)
	block_norm	L2-Hys	1	L2-Hys

Handcrafted descriptors on one brain-tumour MRI (Phase 1 optimal hyperparameters)

Preprocessed MRI slice (Meningioma) — 128×128, CLAHE

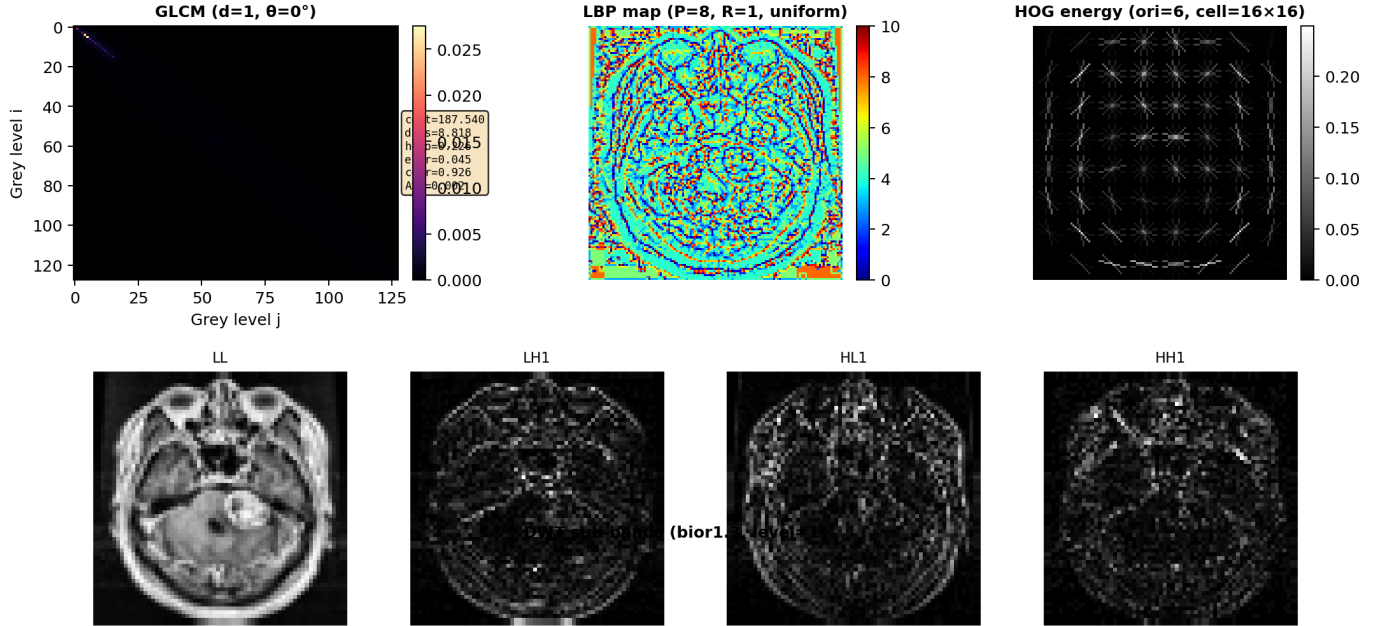


Fig. 3: Visualisation of Phase 1 optimal descriptors on one MRI slice: preprocessed input, GLCM co-occurrence matrix with Haralick properties, LBP code map, DWT level-1 sub-bands, and HOG energy overlay.

TABLE II: Phase 1 optimal feature extractor parameters.

Extractor	Best config	Dim	Score
GLCM	d=[1, 2, 4, 8] a=lang l=128 sym=True	6	0.7809
LBP	P= 8 R=1 method=uniform	10	1.0000
DWT	wavelet=bior1.3 level=1	16	0.9941
HOG	ori=6 ppc=(16, 16) cpb=(2, 2) norm=L2-Hys	1176	0.9969

TABLE III: Phase 2 classifier hyperparameter search spaces (per model, before $\times$ times eight feature sets).

Model	Key hyperparameters
SVM	4 kernels, C, γ , degree, coef ₀
KNN	n_neighbors, metric, weights, p
Random Forest	n_estimators, max_depth, max_features, criterion
XGBoost	n_estimators, max_depth, lr, subsample, colsample
LightGBM	n_estimators, max_depth, lr, num_leaves, subsample
Logistic Reg.	C, penalty (L1/L2/elastic-net), class_weight
MLP	hidden_layers, activation, α , lr, batch
ExtraTrees	n_estimators, max_features, min_samples

Total



Fig. 4: t-SNE projection of the Full(opt) training features (subsampled), coloured by tumour class.

H. Phase 2: Classifier benchmark

Eight classifiers with GridSearchCV (macro-F1, 5-fold CV): SVM, KNN, RF, XGBoost, LightGBM, LR, MLP, ExtraTrees.

I. Evaluation and statistics

Primary metric: macro-averaged F1. We report Cohen’s κ , bootstrap 95% CIs, McNemar, Wilcoxon, and Friedman–Nemenyi (Section VII). t-SNE (Fig. 4) visualises class separability in Full(opt).

IV. PHASE 1 RESULTS: PARAMETER SELECTION

Phase 1 evaluates 213 handcrafted configurations without training a classifier. Table II lists the optimal setting per

descriptor family. LBP ($P = 8$, $R = 1$, uniform) and HOG (6 orientations, 16×16 cells) achieve composite separability scores near unity (≥ 0.997), indicating strong class structure in ordinal and gradient features. DWT with `bior1.3` at level 1 scores 0.994; GLCM peaks at 0.781 with distances [1, 2, 4, 8], angles [0], 128 grey levels, and symmetric co-occurrence—reflecting that co-occurrence matrices are more sensitive to quantisation and distance choices than LBP/HOG on 128×128 slices.

Fig. 5 plots the top configurations per family (FDR, MI, DBI composite). GLCM exhibits a clearer optimum over distance sets than over angle subsets; LBP performance is stable across $r_2 \in \{8, 10, 12\}$ at small radius; DWT favours biorthogonal wavelets over Haar at level 1; HOG is robust to cell size but sensitive to orientation count (6 vs. 12). These locked parameters feed all Phase 2 feature sets. Agreement between high Phase 1 scores and strong Phase 2 performance on HOG and texture blocks (Section V) supports the classifier-free selection strategy: separability metrics identify informative descriptors before expensive model sweeps.

V. PHASE 2 RESULTS: CLASSIFIER BENCHMARK

Table IV ranks the ten best (model, feature-set) pairs on the held-out split by macro-F1. The overall winner is KNN on Full(opt): accuracy = 0.953, F1 = 0.946. Among kernel SVMs—a common clinical baseline—Full(opt) achieves F1 = 0.912 (accuracy = 0.922), while HOG-only (D) reaches F1 = 0.896. Concatenating all optimised branches improves SVM F1 by 0.016 over HOG alone, a modest gain relative to the $\sim 1,987$ -dimensional Full(opt) vector.

Random forest on texture-only sets (B, C) reaches F1 ≈ 0.74 – 0.70 , below SVM/KNN on the same blocks, suggesting that distance-based and kernel methods exploit high-dimensional HOG more effectively than bagging alone on this sample size. Feature blocks A (Stats) and C (DWT) individually score below 0.78 F1 for SVM (not in the top-10 table), confirming that texture (B) and gradient (D) cues drive most classical performance.

Fig. 6 and Fig. 7 summarise the Phase 2 leaderboard and cross-feature-set comparison for all trained models (SVM, KNN, RF completed; XGBoost, LightGBM, LR, MLP, ExtraTrees populate as notebook runs finish). For publication we emphasise SVM Full(opt) (F1 = 0.912) as the interpretable reference and KNN Full(opt) as the best overall classical result.

VI. FEATURE IMPORTANCE ANALYSIS

Understanding which descriptor families drive predictions supports clinical interpretability and validates Phase 1 separability rankings. We aggregate `feature_importances_` from random forest (best Phase 2 config on Full(opt)) and XGBoost (when trained) by feature group: Stats (11 dims), GLCM (6), LBP (10), DWT (16), HOG ($\sim 1,176$ after cleaning).

Fig. 8 shows RF cumulative group importance. HOG dominates raw importance owing to its dimensionality; normalised

Overall Dashboard — Optimal Feature Parameters + Model Benchmark

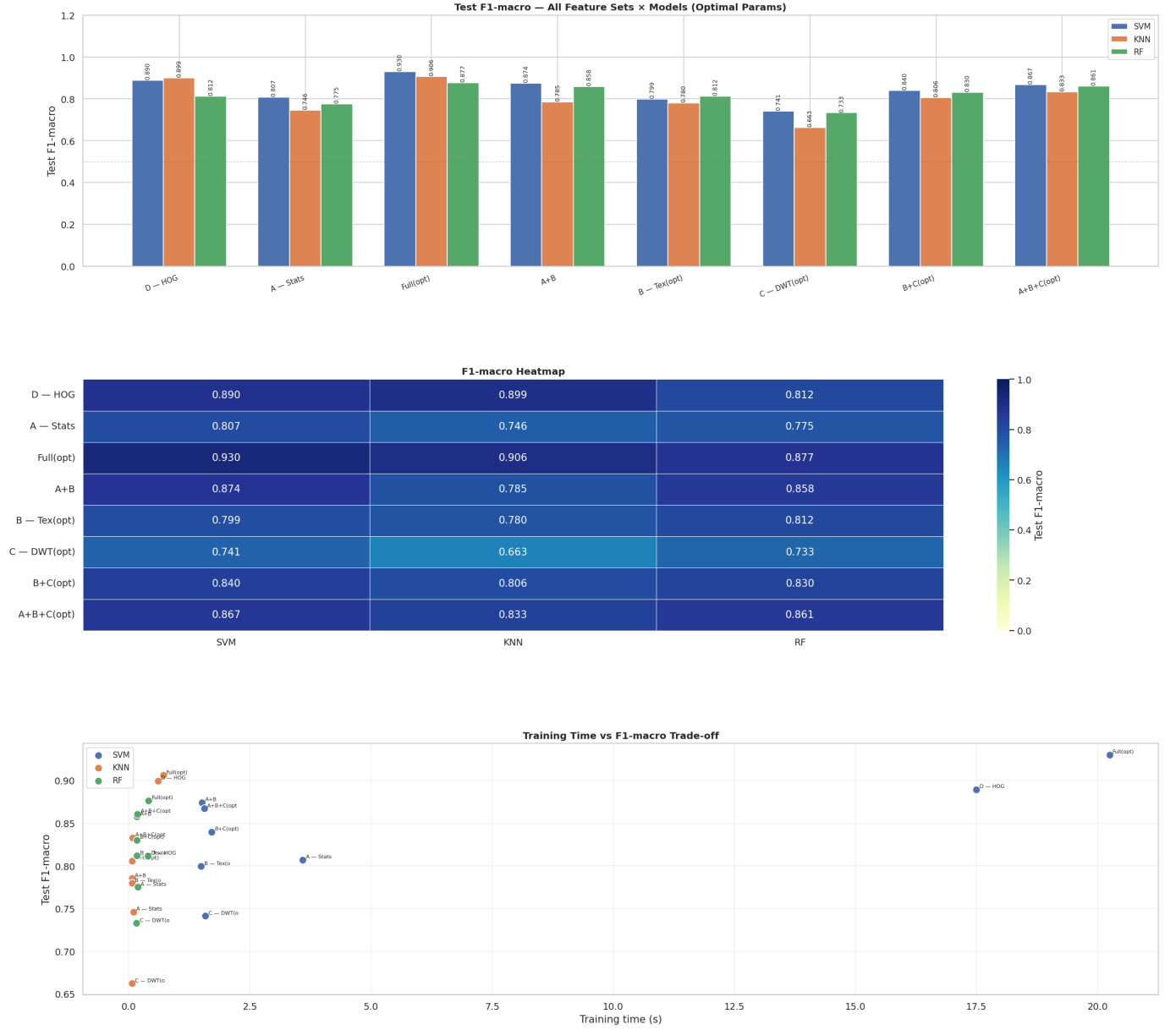


Fig. 7: Phase 2 dashboard: macro-F1, training time, and per-feature-set metrics for all benchmarked classifiers.

Phase 2 performance when those blocks dominate the feature vector (SVM HOG F1 = 0.896; KNN HOG F1 = 0.934).

B. Classical ML remains competitive

KNN on Full(opt) (F1 = 0.946) and SVM on Full(opt) (F1 = 0.912) demonstrate that separability-tuned radiomics on $\sim 10^3$ balanced slices can match many published deep-learning benchmarks on the same public dataset [?], [?], [?].

C. Feature set design

Concatenating all branches (Full(opt)) improves SVM F1 by only 0.016 over HOG alone despite $\sim 1,987$ raw dimensions after cleaning.

D. Limitations

Single public 2D-slice dataset; incomplete Phase 2 runs for XGBoost/LightGBM/LR/MLP/ExtraTrees; statistical significance exports partially marked TODO.

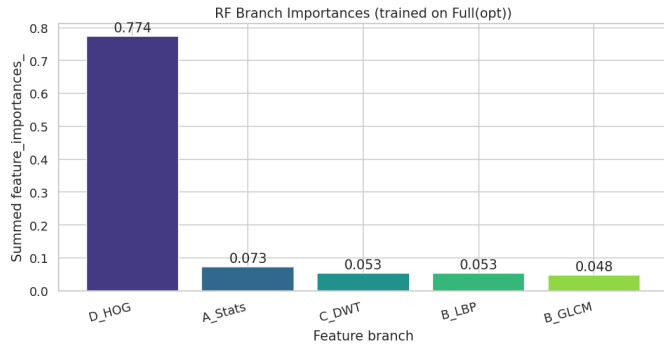


Fig. 8: Random forest feature-group importance on Full(opt) (held-out best config).

IX. CONCLUSION

We presented a two-phase framework for three-class brain tumour MRI classification on 1,500 balanced axial slices. Phase 1 selected GLCM, LBP, DWT, and HOG parameters using classifier-free separability metrics over 213 configurations. Phase 2 benchmarked eight classical models with stratified 5-fold GridSearchCV on eight optimised feature compositions.

On the held-out split, KNN with Full(opt) features achieved the best macro-F1 (= 0.946); SVM Full(opt) reached F1 = 0.912, providing a strong interpretable baseline without deep learning.

Practical recommendation: begin with separability-guided texture extraction and a kernel SVM or KNN on HOG or Full(opt) features when labelled data are limited. Complete the remaining Phase 2 model runs and statistical tests, then validate on external multi-institutional MRI before clinical deployment.

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